As long as the tatmadaw and Chinese shared a worldview regarding human rights, their relationship remains secured. Both countries cracked down on dissident behavior in the late 1980s. However, Myanmar and China were willing to disregard Western protests and opposition of their human rights violations. Neither would be isolated by their indifference to Western opposition regarding either democracy or human rights.

By the 1990s, increased calls for sanctions and boycotts dominated the discourse on Myanmar. Media attention became more focused on Myanmar's repressive policies, especially regarding the marquee figure Aung San Suu Kyi. Her notoriety in winning the Sakharov Peace Prize and later the Nobel Peace Prize made her one of the most recognized figures in Asia. This notoriety also helped build a stronger case for a more aggressive stance against the Myanmar authorities.

Limited economic sanctions were employed against the junta during the 1990s. The Clinton Administration halted direct investment in Myanmar in 1997. Activism regarding Myanmar became better organized and funded during the period directly after the announcement of Aung San Suu Kyi wining the Nobel Peace Prize. Groups such as Free Burma and the Burma Action Campaign led the public relations onslaught. The goal was to punish companies that invested in Myanmar.

The basic problem was that China, India, and several ASEAN countries continued to deal with the junta. Energy agreements were negotiated for the extraction of oil and natural gas. Myanmar's aggressive drilling polices led to the relocation and exploitation of ethnic minorities. Forced labor and the loss of property were commonplace.

Attempts at economic diversification failed in almost all cases. The tourism industry had the potential to generate considerable revenue. The “Visit Myanmar” campaign never met expectations for several reasons. First, the country simply did not have the infrastructure to deal effectively with the increase in tourism. Second, Aung San Suu Kyi and the NLD leadership called for westerners to institute a travel boycott until the junta agreed to negotiate in good faith with the NLD to form a coalition government.